calculations may lead proliferators to adopt risky and destabilizing behavior.

We contextualize our competing positions, as well as the standard nuclear optimist and pessimist claims, as part of what we call outcome- and process-based approaches to nuclear proliferation. A key difference between optimistic and pessimistic arguments of all stripes is the emphasis they place on different aspects of crisis behavior. Optimists tend to stress the ultimately stable outcomes of past crises between nuclear powers, while pessimists focus on the potentially catastrophic processes by which the crises erupted and escalated. We argue that both sides make valid points; nuclear weapons may both encourage the outbreak of conflict and encourage states to ensure that violence remains limited. Whether the outcome- or process-based approach is ultimately superior depends on which aspect of crisis behavior one thinks is most significant.

Our approach has several important advantages. The book's debate-oriented structure, which alternates from point to counterpoint, gives the volume a conversational quality. This should make our analysis widely accessible while maintaining scholarly rigor. And it exposes the reader to competing sides of the South Asian proliferation argument in the space of a single volume. Our arguments, which differ in important ways from standard optimist and pessimist analyses, should add nuance to the nuclear proliferation debate.

∞∞∞

The book proceeds in the following manner. In chapter 2, we lay out the historical and theoretical background behind the current debate over South Asian nuclear proliferation. The chapter briefly traces the origins of the Indo-Pakistani conflict, outlines the history of the South Asian proliferation process, and locates disagreements within the policy and scholarly communities over nuclear weapons' effects on the region.

In chapter 3, we offer competing theoretical frameworks for understanding nuclear weapons' effects on Indo-Pakistani conflict